

Build Steps

Cowork is task-driven — give Copilot a job, optionally schedule it, let it use your M365.

1 Open Copilot Cowork

Open Microsoft 365 Copilot and switch to Cowork mode (left rail). Confirm the surfaces you have available — Cowork can act on your behalf across:

- Outlook (read, summarise, draft, send, schedule)
- Teams (chats, channels, post messages, read history)
- Calendar (find times, create meetings, prep briefs)
- SharePoint & OneDrive (read files, write Word/Excel/PowerPoint to your files)
- Power BI (semantic models, reports, DAX queries)

2 Paste the Headline Task

Open a new Cowork task and paste the prompt below. This is the worked example for Finance — adapt names, channels, and Power BI reports to your tenant before running.

On the 1st working day of each month at 8:00am, run the Month-End Variance Pack:

1. Read the 'Finance Budget vs Actuals' Power BI semantic model. Pull each cost centre: budget, actual, variance amount, variance %.
2. Flag cost centres with variance % above $\pm 10\%$ as 'review needed'.
3. For each flagged cost centre, search my mailbox for messages from the cost centre owner in the last 30 days mentioning that cost centre or its category — pull any variance context they already gave verbally.
4. Build an Excel workbook (Cost Centre, Owner, Budget, Actual, Variance, Status, Suggested Driver from email evidence).
5. For each flagged owner, draft a short email asking them to confirm the driver and submit a variance note. Leave drafts in my Drafts.
6. Save the workbook to /Finance/Month End/<month>.xlsx and email me the link with a one-paragraph summary.

3 Set the Schedule

In the task panel, choose Schedule and configure:

Frequency	Monthly
Run Time	1st working day, 08:00 GMT
Execution Mode	Inline (recommended) — task remembers context across runs

4 Verify the First Run

Run once now (Run now) before scheduling kicks in. Confirm:

- Numbers in the Excel match the Power BI report (spot-check 3 rows)
- Email mining surfaces real context, not noise
- Draft emails reference the correct cost centre and amount
- The workbook is in /Finance/Month End/ and the link works

Try These Live

Copy any of these into a new Cowork task — one-shot or scheduled.

Spend Reconciliation

Pull invoice-related emails from the last 60 days (sender contains 'invoice', 'AP', 'accounts payable'). Cross-reference against the 'Finance Budget vs Actuals' Power BI model. Build an Excel workbook of any invoices over €10k not yet reflected in actuals.

Forecast Outreach

Read the latest forecast in the Power BI report. For each cost centre owner whose YE forecast is more than 15% over annual budget, draft a short email asking for a mitigation plan by Friday. Leave drafts.

FP&A Friday Note

Every Friday at 4pm: take the top 5 cost centres by absolute variance from the Power BI report. Draft a Teams message to the FP&A channel: numbers, owners, status. Leave the draft.

How to Think About This Teammate

Cowork replaces:

- Hand-building month-end variance packs
- Chasing cost centre owners for context by email
- Reconciling AP against actuals row by row

With:

- ✓ A complete variance pack on day 1 of month-end
- ✓ Drafted owner outreach with the right numbers in
- ✓ Spend & forecast pulled together in one workflow

Not a chatbot. A scheduled teammate with full access to your M365.

Tip for real-world use

Finance is one place where 'do not send automatically' is non-negotiable. Keep every outbound email as a draft for review, and ask Cowork to cite the Power BI visual or Excel cell it derived each number from. Trust earned, audit trail intact.

You've built a Cowork teammate ✓

You now have a Copilot teammate that can:

- Run month-end variance in one task
- Cut close cycle days, not finance heads
- Pull forecast & spend evidence in parallel
- Make owner outreach grounded and consistent